

What Is Art Deco and Why Is It Popular Again?

Art Deco is an international artistic style that was popular in the 1920s and 1930s.

Now, interest in the style and its qualities is growing. A new generation is enjoying the style's roots and turning it into something new.

A public showing, or exhibition, at the Museum of the City of New York provides a look at the style that helped define the city 100 years ago.

Famous Art Deco buildings include the Chrysler Building, the Empire State Building, Rockefeller Center and Radio City Music Hall.

The public showing, called "Art Deco City: New York Postcards from the Leonard A. Lauder Collection," also has clothing and film clips from the time.

In London, the Victoria and Albert Museum has a collection of day and evening clothing, jewelry and more. The collection comes from Les Ballets Russes, a dance company that had a major effect on fashion.

And in Paris, organizers of the 2024 Olympics created Art Deco posters last year to celebrate the games and mark the one hundred years since the 1924 Olympics, which Paris also hosted.

This image provided by the Museum of the City of New York shows a 1920s dress made of black silk chiffon with brocaded gold geometric motifs and red silk crepe. (Museum of the City of New York via AP)

A style of the 1920s and 30s

Experts have different opinions about Art Deco. Design writer Arricca Elin Sansone, for example, said last year in *Elle Décor* magazine: "Ask three historians to define the term Art Deco, and you'll likely get three varying answers."

Appearing after World War I, the first Art Deco era had a spirit of creativity and freedom. With the aim of appearing modern, the style became one of the most important forms of design in the 1920s and early 1930s.

The Art Deco style is believed to have first appeared at the 1925 International Exhibition of Modern Decorative and Industrial Arts, in Paris.

The early 1930s saw the development of the style in Miami where South Beach's Art Deco District is popular with visitors and a center for design.

In some large cities, low-rise buildings of two or three floors turned into landscapes of high-rise skyscrapers. Public and private spaces showed themes involving geometrical designs and luxurious materials.

In transportation, faster cars and better trains suggested a new age while jazz music urged people to celebrate.

This image provided by the Museum of the City of New York shows black silk satin and gold-tone leather evening shoes made by Delman Black in 1936. (Museum of the City of New York via AP)

“A fashionable renaissance”

The same energy can be found in today’s fashion shows and red-carpet events for stars. Some of today’s colorful clothing suggests the Jazz Age, another name for the period when Art Deco was popular. Stars like Zendaya, Gigi Hadid, Beyoncé and Demi Lovato have used elements of the Deco era in new ways.

“The aesthetic of the 1920s is enjoying a fashionable renaissance,” said Kirsty Thatcher of the Australian fashion magazine *Russh*. A “renaissance” represents a rebirth of something from the past.

New York-based interior designer Vanessa DeLeon told the Associated Press, “The boldness and elegance of Art Deco are what appeals to me.”

Jamie Watkins and Tom Kennedy of the London design company Divine Savages include Art Deco elements in their collections of products for the home. Watkins suggested: “It’s no wonder we’re drawn to it again.”

Lynda Klich is the co-organizer or curator of the exhibition at the Museum of the City of New York. Klich noted that postcards were the social media of their day. Travelers at the time busily wrote messages to friends and family. New York’s famous Art Deco buildings appear in over 250 postcards. There is also a selection of clothing from the 1920s, shoes and other objects.

“Art Deco was the look that sold the city to the world,” said co-curator Lilly Tuttle.

The exhibition in New York City runs through February 17.

I’m John Russell.

Kim Cook reported on this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

style – n. รูปแบบเฉพาะของการออกแบบที่ได้รับความนิยมในช่วงเวลาหนึ่ง

fashion – n. รูปแบบที่นิยมหรือเป็นที่โดดเด่น (เช่นในเสื้อผ้าเครื่องแต่งกาย) ในช่วงเวลาหนึ่ง

poster – n. รูปภาพขนาดใหญ่ที่มักใช้ในการโฆษณาการแสดงหรือภาพยนตร์

vary – v. มีหรือแสดงความแตกต่างระหว่างสิ่งของหรือรายการต่างๆ

theme – n. คุณสมบัติหรือลักษณะเฉพาะ; หัวข้อหรือประเด็นของการนำเสนอทางศิลปะ

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. According to the article, what is Art Deco?

- A. A new artistic movement developing in the 2020s.
- B. An international artistic style popular in the 1920s and 1930s.
- C. A local design trend originating in New York City.
- D. A specific type of architecture found only in Paris.

2. What is mentioned about the current interest in Art Deco?

- A. It has completely disappeared as a new generation prefers modern designs.
- B. Interest in the style and its qualities is growing, with a new generation adapting it.
- C. Only historians are interested in studying its roots.
- D. It is only popular in London and Paris, not in New York.

3. Where can one currently find a public showing of Art Deco that helped define New York City 100 years ago?

- A. At the Metropolitan Museum of Art.
- B. At the Museum of the City of New York.
- C. At the Empire State Building.
- D. At Rockefeller Center.

4. Which of the following is NOT listed as a famous Art Deco building in the article?

- A. The Chrysler Building.
- B. The Empire State Building.
- C. The Statue of Liberty.
- D. Radio City Music Hall.

5. Besides postcards, what other items are featured in the New York City exhibition titled “Art Deco City: New York Postcards from the Leonard A. Lauder Collection”?

- A. Automobiles and industrial machinery.
- B. Contemporary art pieces and sculptures.
- C. Clothing and film clips from the time.

D. Historical documents and architectural blueprints.

6. What kind of collection related to Art Deco is housed at the Victoria and Albert Museum in London?

- A. A collection of rare Art Deco furniture.
- B. A collection of day and evening clothing, jewelry, and more from Les Ballets Russes.
- C. A display of architectural models from the Art Deco era.
- D. An exhibition of Art Deco photography.

7. How did organizers of the 2024 Paris Olympics use Art Deco last year?

- A. They built new Art Deco stadiums for the games.
- B. They created Art Deco posters to celebrate and mark the 100 years since the 1924 Olympics.
- C. They commissioned Art Deco-style uniforms for the athletes.
- D. They designed the Olympic medals in an Art Deco style.

8. What do experts generally agree upon regarding the definition of Art Deco?

- A. There is a single, universally accepted definition.
- B. Experts have differing opinions, often providing varying answers.
- C. The definition is straightforward and has not changed over time.
- D. Only design writer Arricca Elin Sansone can accurately define it.

9. What characterized the spirit and aim of the first Art Deco era, which appeared after World War I?

- A. A focus on traditional, conservative designs.
- B. A spirit of creativity and freedom, aiming to appear modern.
- C. A return to pre-war artistic styles.
- D. An emphasis on low-cost, mass-produced goods.

10. Where is the Art Deco style believed to have first appeared?

- A. In New York City in the early 1920s.
- B. At the 1925 International Exhibition of Modern Decorative and Industrial Arts in Paris.
- C. In London at the Victoria and Albert Museum.
- D. In Miami's South Beach district.

11. Which city saw significant development of the Art Deco style in the early 1930s, becoming a center for design?

- A. London.

- B. Paris.
- C. New York.
- D. Miami.

12. During the Art Deco period, what kind of transformation occurred in some large cities and what themes were shown in public and private spaces?

- A. Low-rise buildings replaced high-rise structures, and spaces showed rustic themes.
- B. High-rise skyscrapers emerged from low-rise buildings, displaying geometrical designs and luxurious materials.
- C. Cities remained largely unchanged, with spaces focusing on natural, organic themes.
- D. Public spaces became simple and minimalist, while private spaces were ornate.

13. What elements of transportation and music characterized the Art Deco era, suggesting a new age?

- A. Slower cars, horse-drawn carriages, and classical orchestral music.
- B. Faster cars, better trains, and jazz music.
- C. Bicycles, walking, and folk music.
- D. Airships, steamships, and opera.

14. How does today's fashion scene reflect the influence of the Art Deco era?

- A. It largely ignores the Art Deco style, focusing on completely new aesthetics.
- B. Colorful clothing and stars like Zendaya and Beyoncé use elements of the Deco era in new ways.
- C. Modern fashion is exclusively focused on conservative, minimalist designs.
- D. Art Deco is only seen in historical documentaries, not in current fashion shows.

15. What does Kirsty Thatcher of Russh magazine mean by stating that 'The aesthetic of the 1920s is enjoying a fashionable renaissance'?

- A. That the fashion of the 1920s is completely outdated.
- B. That the style is undergoing a rebirth or revival in popularity.
- C. That fashion from the 1920s is only appreciated by historians.
- D. That the 1920s was a period of decline for fashion.